Fintech
Hackathon

JUDGE GUIDE · LONDON · 13 OCTOBER 2026

Ninety seconds, four questions.

Every team gets a 1:30 demo and the same four criteria. Look for the team that solved a real money problem for a real person, and proved it.

1 How judging works

20:30 Review your projects
Start as entries arrive. Watch each demo to 1:30, score it, then swipe.

Pick one per track
Your best in Payments, Access to finance, and Fraud and security.

Shortlist
Score every judge's picks. The top six present live.

21:00 Winners
One per track, plus one overall. Then we close.

2 The four criteria

Score each from 1 to 5. The portal does the weighting.

30% Real-world impact
A named person with a real money problem.

25% Originality
Something new, in one sentence. Not a chatbot on a bank statement.

25% Execution
One flow that works start to finish. Proof beats polish.

20% Trust
What could go wrong with money or data, and how they protect users.

Good to know

- Open your judge link once. It remembers you.
- Keys: **1–5** to score, → contender, ← pass.
- Stop every video at 1:30.
- Score alone, then discuss.
- Know a team? Say so and step out.
- Ties go to the higher impact score.

3 What to look for

Reward

- A clear user and problem in the first 20 seconds
- One complete, working flow
- Smart use of existing data, like Open Banking
- Honesty about what is mocked

Resist

- Polish with no clear user
- Several half-built features
- Tech-stack tours and slides
- Marking your first videos too harshly

4 Ask every finalist

1. Who exactly is this for?
2. What did you build tonight?
3. What breaks first with real money?
4. What could go right at scale?
5. What is mocked, and what would make it real?

"Ambition is not the signal. Judgment under a constraint is the signal."

Magomed Kurbaitaev, on a year of judging hackathons